

Furthermore, as an outsider, he accepts he had to work harder than a native-born player.

"More than seeing me as an Indian-origin player or even a New Zealand player, the challenge comes from simply being a foreigner. In Germany, for example, if two players are at the same level and one is German and the other is a New Zealander or Indian or whatever, then obviously they take the German player. That's why it does become a lot more difficult. And because I don't have a European passport, it's a lot harder to unlock a lot of countries in Europe. And I know for sure it would be the same if you come from India. There are so many hurdles you have to overcome — the way people make their decisions, based on where you're from or if they have to go through other issues with visas and stuff. These things do play a factor for sure," he says.

What would be his hardest challenge came in 2020, though. Just as he was poised to break out with a transfer to newly promoted Bundesliga side Werder Bremen, Sarpreet got diagnosed with a significant osteitis pubis injury. He calls the subsequent phase the toughest of his career.

"There's nothing I can change about it. I do wish I could have continued at a much higher level. It wasn't a question of ability or talent. I had a couple of good loan spells [with Bundesliga 2 sides FC Nürnberg (2020) and SSV Jahn Regensburg (2021)]. I was also in line to sign a Bundesliga contract when I had my injury. It was a tough time for me. It still is a tough time sometimes when I think about what I could have been doing," he admits. "There is a physical challenge to confront, but what people don't realise is the mental side of it as well. The strain that you have because of all the things that go wrong. Day to day you're by yourself — you go to training for four or five hours and then the rest of the day you're stuck by yourself with no one to speak to," says Sarpreet, who would move to Bundesliga 2 side Hansa Rostock and now plays for União de Leiria in

Portugal's second division.

What eventually helped Sarpreet get through that phase was simply going through the grind of training and accepting that, even if he did his best, there would always be things outside his control. "In Europe I gave my best every day. That's what I try to pride myself on, so that at the end of the day you can't really be left with any regrets. You could have hoped that it goes like this. Or I could have gone to Werder Bremen. Could have played at Bayern more. I could have hoped for these things. But it's nothing I can regret because I did my best," he says.

International success

While Sarpreet's career in Europe has had its share of ups and downs, he's had far more success in his national career, having been a part of the New Zealand team since 2018. His international journey has even brought him to India — he scored his first international goal against Kenya at the 2018 Intercontinental Cup, and followed that up with two assists in New Zealand's 2-1 win over India in the same tournament.

"That was a crazy experience. It's a little bit strange being a Singh and playing for New Zealand in India against India. But the reception I received from the fans was really pleasing. I felt very proud to play that game. It was a little bit different but also a little bit special," he says.

As a New Zealander of Punjabi origin, Sarpreet — or Sari, as most of his teammates call him — says he's influenced by both sides of his cultural upbringing. "The most Punjabi thing about me is that I love *roti*. Sometimes I wish I could have it every single day, but as a sportsperson I obviously can't. I think the most Kiwi thing about me is that I have that small-town mentality. Sometimes you see people in Europe and they're too relaxed.

"There are people who don't put in the effort they should in training. I think coming from New Zealand, I was taught that I have to fight for everything. I have to work hard. Nothing's given to me. But these are values, I guess, that stem from both



Factfile

Age
26

International debut
2018, Intercontinental Cup

Clubs represented
- Wynns Wynton Rufer Soccer Academy - at the age of seven
- Onehunga sports academy - Youth level
- Wellington Phoenix Academy - 2015
- Bayern Munich - 2019
- FC Nürnberg - 2020, on loan
- SSV Jahn Regensburg - 2021, on loan
- Hansa Rostock - 2023
- União de Leiria - 2024

Punjabi and Kiwi cultures," he says.

That isn't to say he doesn't have any opinions on Indian football. As a 14-year-old, Sarpreet recalls going back to his parents' village in Punjab and getting to play with the local kids. "These were boys from the *pind*, so they of course wanted to show me how good they were — but I think I handled myself well," he recalls. While Sarpreet doesn't see himself playing in the ISL anytime soon, he's optimistic about the prospect of overseas players representing the Indian team.

"I think it's a good idea. In multiple countries, they have dual citizenship, and they can choose who they want to play for. I don't see why it should be any different for players of Indian heritage. Because if you do get these players that can come in and help lift the national team, then why not?" he says.